

PEOPLE'S EMPOWERMENT

1975

OFFICIAL XENOPHOBIA
UNLEASHED BY THE
EMERGENCY THAT YEAR
LIVES ON, WITH A FOREIGN
CONNECTION BECOMING
THE MARKER OF AN
INTERNAL FIFTH
COLUMN.

academics lost the freedom they enjoyed in the 1960s to do research in India. The Foreign Contribution Regulation Act, 1976, placed a permanent suspicion on all monetary associations with the outside. Universities had to take official permission to hold conferences. The brilliance of this formulation was a new language for political culture that has long outlived the Emergency in 1975. For every political group today, the Emergency Cultural Code reigns supreme.

For the most part, the 1950s cultural control model is severely crippled. The technological monopoly of the state is in tatters, an unintended consequence of economic liberalisation and globalisation. The sphere that was designated as technological now imploded into diverse forms of life accessed by urban populations. Culture and technology are scrambled today as never before, as are culture and markets. In the face of all this, the regime has been mostly a confused spectator, often running behind events.

Populations have well-moved from being seen as only classic recipients of media in cinema halls, radio sets and televisions. This scenario, a staple of much of 20th century European modernity, based itself on experiences of initial shock and distraction in increasingly technologised cities. Populations in India participate as part producers, consumers and proliferators of media, sourcing from media industries as well as informal networks. Low-cost digital technologies have added to the diffusion of both media infrastructures (video stores, photocopy and design shops, bazaars, cable networks, piracy) and media (images, video, phone SMS/text, sounds). These networks have taken on a life of their own, periodically frustrating control systems.

If the state as public has dissolved itself after globalisation, the main war now is between the legal private (corporations, building firms, media companies multi-nationals) and the non-legal private—local peasants, media pirates, informal markets. In place of the old categories or even along with them, a new public realm has emerged. What is the map of this new public?

The media is the archive of contemporary public realm. Spanning television, radio, print, digital media, sound cultures, the zone that is designated as it emerges in contemporary

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